

KEY EVENTS

146BCE–124CE

■ **c.146BCE** Work begins on the Via Egnatia, a road that will enable Roman armies to access most of the Balkans from Italy.

■ **134–133BCE** Roman forces, led by Scipio Africanus, besiege the Celtiberian stronghold of Numantia, surrounding it with fortifications (known as circumvallations) and attacking it with siege towers. The settlement falls after 16 months.

■ **52BCE** Julius Caesar traps Vercingetorix, leader of the Gallic Revolt, at Alesia. Roman engineers build complex siege-works, preventing relief forces from coming to the defenders' aid.

■ **73CE** Flavius Silva uses his engineers of the Tenth Legion to subdue the mountain fort of Masada.

■ **122–24CE** Hadrian's Wall becomes the Romans' most complex border system. It is 117km (73 miles) long and punctuated by forts.

▼ LEGION INSIGNIA

Imperial legions were proud of their identity. This plaque shows the emblem of the Twentieth Legion, which took part in suppressing the Iceni revolt in Britain (60–61 CE).



KEY DEVELOPMENT

THE ENGINEERING OF ROMAN CONQUEST

The Roman legionaries were not only excellent in combat – they were also highly skilled military engineers, who were called upon to build forts, roads, and siege-works throughout the empire.

A Roman legionary's entrenching tools, it was said, were as dear to him as his sword. When on campaign, legionaries built a marching camp every evening, using a formulaic design that allowed them to organize encampments for up to 5,000 soldiers. Sited on level ground, the camps were usually rectangular, surrounded by a V-shaped ditch and an earth rampart bristling with wooden spikes that the legionaries carried with them.

Once an area was conquered, more permanent forts were built (see p.38), also based on this “playing-card design” – so-called because they had rounded corners. Each fort had four main gates, one of which (the *porta praetoria*) faced enemy territory; a network of roads; and a central block of buildings that contained the *praetorium* (commander's house), the *principia* (headquarters), and a shrine for the legionary standards.

Forts were built in various sizes, to accommodate either whole legions or smaller auxiliary cohorts (around 500 men). They sometimes formed part of complex linear defences, or even walls (such as Hadrian's Wall in Britain). Over time, the earth and turf of many of the original forts were replaced with stone, and, during the later empire, the walls were stronger and had projecting corner towers allowing missile cross-fire. These developments reflected the fact that the forts had become places the army needed to defend, rather than bases from which to dominate the surrounding territory.

ROMAN SIEGES

The legionaries put their skill at constructing fortifications and ramparts to good offensive effect in siege warfare, as they encountered enemy bastions as diverse as the hill-forts of Gaul and Britain, and the elaborate walled towns of Judaea.

If an enemy fort could not be taken by stealth, it had to be surrounded and starved out or, as a last resort, stormed. To isolate an enemy position, the Romans built complex siege-works of ramparts, often with towers from which to fire heavy catapults. At the Siege of Alesia, Julius Caesar oversaw the building of 35km (55 miles) of ramparts that hemmed in Gaulish chieftain Vercingetorix, and cut off supplies. Vast earthworks called assault ramps intimidated



“There was also a **tower** made of the height of **sixty cubits**, and all over plated with **iron**, out of which the **Romans** threw **darts and stones** from the engines”

JOSEPHUS, *THE JEWISH WAR*, c.75CE